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MAMOUN WAZWAZ Anadolu

WEST BANK CRACKDOWN

Israeli forces guard an entrance to Hebron after two soldiers were killed in an attack near the city that also left two suspected gunmen dead. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu vowed retaliation. **WORLD, A2**

Hope, despair for GOP voters in California

Many doubt party's chances in statewide races but are anxious for different leaders.

BY NICOLE NIXON

MISSION VIEJO — Twenty years after the GOP last won a state-level election in California, few Republican voters believe this will be the year.

But they can hope.

"I'm praying, praying, praying that people will come out of the woodwork and show up and just vote for Steve," said Annette Owens, a 65-year-old Orange County resident and longtime special education teacher.

Steve Hilton, a former Fox News host originally from the United Kingdom, faces Xavier Becerra, a longtime Democratic politician who is heavily favored to win the Nov. 3 election to replace term-limited Gov. Gavin Newsom.

While she is "doubtful" Hilton or any other Republicans running statewide will beat their Democratic opponents, Owens says "if anyone's going to do it," it's Hilton.

The candidate had just spent nearly 40 minutes addressing several dozen Orange County moms in Mission Viejo, a hilly and affluent enclave speckled with golf courses and Spanish colonial architecture.

Sipping mimosas in a glass-walled event space overlooking the city's verdant public course, women — and a couple of tagalong husbands — listened as Hilton and local Republicans argued for a change after 16 years of Democrats controlling California government.

"We can make this a place where people follow their dreams and build their lives, and that's the ultimate test: that people are moving back to California after my first four years in government," Hilton said.

Rachel Darvish drove from her home in Pacific Palisades to support the gubernatorial candidate. In the aftermath of the January 2025 fires, Darvish was captured on viral video angrily confronting Newsom as he toured the wreckage. She joined the Republican Party

[See **Republicans,** A7]

TRUMP TARGETS SENATE RACE IN ALASKA

Justice Department's legal move aims to prevent certification of a Democratic win.

BY NICHOLAS RICCARDI

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Friday said he told his administration to file its lawsuit to block certification of the U.S. Senate race in Alaska if Republican Sen. Dan Sullivan loses, kicking off what many fear could become a lengthy battle between the government and states over certifying an election where the president's party is struggling.

"I'm the one that said do it," Trump told reporters as he landed for a campaign rally in Florida.

The lawsuit, filed late Thursday by the Department of Justice, centers on one of the president's longstanding complaints in the Senate race — the presence of a second candidate named Dan Sullivan who Republicans fear could siphon away votes from the incumbent in what's likely to be a photo-finish contest with Democrat Mary Peltola, the state's former congresswoman.

The department has increasingly been used to bolster the president's political operation, targeting his enemies and suing Democratic-controlled states before the election. Democrats and many voting rights advocates have long feared that the administration will try to block certification of elections that Trump's party loses, much as he unsuccessfully tried to do when he lost the White House race to Democrat Joe Biden.

U.S. Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche said that was unlikely outside of extreme circumstances. "It is not DOJ's intention to, and it's never our intention to, improperly interfere with elections or the state certification proc-

[See **Alaska,** A6]

Billionaire tax faces a cash avalanche

BY SEEMA MEHTA

More than $351 million in political donations has been poured into a high-stakes contest about a proposed wealth tax on the November ballot, making it one of the most costly campaigns in California history.

About 90% of the money is being spent to defeat a statewide initiative to impose a new tax on the assets of billionaires, a multifaceted opposition effort bankrolled primarily by ultra-rich Californians being targeted by a measure that supporters call an economic reckoning.

The billionaire tax, Proposition 40, would levy a one-time 5% tax on many assets of California billionaires who lived in the state as of Jan. 1.

Millions of dollars continue to flow into the campaigns of three intertwined ballot initiatives at the center of the debate: Proposition 40, and Propositions 41 and Proposition 42, which would neuter Proposition 40 through strategic, esoteric tax law changes.

"The pro-40 campaign picked a fight and then came to that fight with a butter knife against a nuclear arsenal," said GOP strategist Rob Stutzman, who is not involved in any of the wealth-tax-related ballot measures. "Because they're so well funded, in today's multifaceted media world, they are able to show up everywhere from network TV to inside video games. That is a very, very large advantage few campaigns ever get to have."

But, Stutzman warned, money does not guarantee a win.

In the most expensive ballot measure fights in California history, $463 million was spent on two gambling proposals 2022. The initiatives pitted some of California's most successful Native American tribes with gaming interests against gambling corpora-

[See **Wealth tax,** A9]



VICTORIA MARIE

MALIBU millionaire and animal lover Alexander Lewis passed away in 2020.

Twists in a charitable bequest

Executor gave millions to her friends' new nonprofits

BY ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN

Alexander Lewis loved pets so much that he left most of his roughly $28-million fortune to animal charities.

But he didn't say which charities. He left that decision to his longtime friend and accountant, Victoria Marie, naming her as the executor of his will.

When Lewis died in 2020, Marie thought of her friends.

"It just dawned on me ... are you involved with any domestic animal nonprofits??" she wrote on Instagram to Laura Nativo, who had once competed on a dog training reality show and was building a following as a pet lifestyle personality.

Another friend, Wanda Love, was a longtime head of a local chamber of commerce who participated in charitable causes.

Both women started animal charities.

When the assets from Lewis' estate were distributed in 2024, Nativo's Preston's Planet Foundation, whose mission was to train service dogs for women and children, got about $9 million, including a Malibu mansion

[See **Estate,** A14]

$180-million water deal is under fire

State disputes it paid too much for too little, points out pact's terms in perpetuity.

BY IAN JAMES

The Newsom administration is coming under fire for paying $180 million to a private investment firm that speculates on water in exchange for a relatively small amount of additional water for Sacramento River salmon.

The goal of the deal, the administration says, is to purchase water used by a Northern California farm in order to leave the water in the river to help fish and the environment.

Some environmental advocates, however, fear the deal could set a precedent for overcharging California taxpayers in a water-constrained future. State officials and supporters of the deal say it's not that simple because, among other things, it's a one-time payment for water in perpetuity, not just for one year.

But Barry Nelson, an advisor for the Golden State Salmon Assn., said the small amount doesn't justify the cost.

"This is extraordinarily expensive water," said Nelson, who, along with leaders of other environmental and fishing groups, wrote to state regulators raising concern. He said it "seems like a really bad investment for the public."

Peter Drekmeier, policy director of the group Yosemite Rivers Alliance, agreed.

"The taxpayers are expected to pay top dollar for an amount of water that's not really going to move the needle, and that's just wrong," Drekmeier said.

The Newsom administration defends the purchase. Ryan Endean, a spokesperson for the state Department of Water Resources, said it represents a win for salmon and water users.

"It will deliver water for the sake of native fish species ... even in critically dry years when salmon will benefit the most," Endean said.

[See **Water,** A8]

SoFi feud with Inglewood finds its way to ballot

BY SAM FARMER

SoFi Stadium is going strong. The deal that built it is in a smoldering heap.

A decade ago, Rams owner Stan Kroenke and Inglewood Mayor James T. Butts Jr. happily dug ceremonial shovels into the dirt at Hollywood Park, celebrating the impending construction of the world's most expensive stadium.

Now they're on opposite sides of a court fight that has spilled onto the Nov. 3 ballot and threatens further development on the nearly 300-acre site.

The feud started over billboards. Last year, Inglewood signed a deal with WOW Media to put electronic advertising all around the city — 60 digital signs carrying 108 screens. Some are bus-shelter-sized kiosks, while others are giant street displays up to 22 feet tall and positioned on sidewalks and medians.

Those present problems for SoFi Stadium, Intuit Dome and the Forum because they have their own advertising deals and sponsors who paid for exclusivity. Those venues collectively sued Inglewood and WOW Media to block the deal, raising this scenario in a court filing: "Will Pepsi want to sponsor the Super Bowl, knowing Coca-Cola could pay WOW to put up full-motion billboards next to the stadium?"

Skip Miller, lead attorney for the city, said the kiosks are "quite nice and blend in with the surrounding areas," and that they are connected to a network that provides

[See **Inglewood,** A8]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

L.A. GEM REEMERGES

The Hotel Clark, born in 1914 and idle for more than 30 years, has reopened in recent weeks. Here is the building's staircase. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Bass tops Raman in fundraising

But council member has twice as much cash on hand in final stretch of race. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Crumbl's viral boom cools off

Cookie chain closes seven stores in SoCal and dozens across the U.S. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Lots of sun.
L.A. Basin: 79/59. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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